

KF31 Expanded Version of Teachings

Karis is an invitation to a relationship based on mutual generosity.

“Search me, O God, and know my heart. Examine me and know my thoughts. See if there is any way in me that causes pain, and lead me in the ways of eternity.” (Psalm 139:23–24)

0:01 OPENING

0:02 PRESENTING

0:06 KARIS CIRCULATION

0:07 GUIDELINES & LIMITATIONS

0:08 MINDFULNESS & MEDITATION TRAINING

In **Calming Breath** meditation, we say the word *CALM* to ourselves. By managing life’s difficulties calmly, we reveal our trust in God. Calm is characteristic of the peace that passes all understanding.¹ This peace cannot be understood by the Idol Self or by the world. It is the peace that Jesus offers to us when we orient our lives to Him, turning away from pride and refusing to pursue the imagined perfections demanded of us by the Idol Self.² When our internal conflicts are laid to rest, we can peacefully plant orientation into our own lives, our communities, and the world.

Take time throughout the day to calm yourself and give God a chance to guide you into orientation. Here is what we’ve learned from James: “The fruit of orientation is planted in peace by those who make peace.”³

Calming Breath

1. Prepare

Settle into a meditation posture, and breathe. Straighten your neck by lifting the back of your head and lower your chin a little. Now, let your shoulders fall back. Experiment with what works for you. You might begin with a silent prayer for peace within yourself and in your life. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

2. Scan for tension

As you inhale, explore your body for tension. You might start with your feet and ankles. On the exhale, try to release any tension that you find. Let your muscles drop or soften. *(Pause)* Remember to scan for tension in your face. Learn to notice what your face is doing in any situation. Your face tells more of your story than your words or beliefs. Breathe and let go. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

3. Use sound

When you feel ready, use the word *CALM* as a centering word. You might try singing the “ahm” sound. Vibrations produced in our bodies by different sounds have different effects. For example, low pitches tend to relax the nervous system.⁴ Explore a pitch that feels healing to you and maintain that pitch for a few moments. You might then wish to slide into another pitch that feels healing. I will give you an

example. *(Give an example)* Release tension in your body as you sing. Continue at your own pace for one minute. *(Pause 1 minute)*

4. Use breath

Now, if you wish, let go of singing the word and just repeat it within your mind, releasing tension with a long exhaling breath. Scan your body with a deep, long inhale before the releasing exhale. Continue scanning and releasing body tension. *(Pause for 1 minute)*

5. Rest

Draw your mind away from the word and the breath. Simply rest in stillness for one minute. *(Pause for 1 minute)*

Now gently stretch, open your eyes, and re-engage with the meeting.

Take a deep breath.

(Go straight to the Confession to allow time for the Toolbox)

0:20 KARIS CONFESSION

0:21 TOOLBOX

KF Confession 7 begins a dynamic move toward our True Self:

We commit now to live in reality, choosing to believe rather than judge.

In the last lesson, we looked at the reality of our natural cycles as material creatures. In Ecclesiastes, chapter 3, King Solomon mentions a variety of different cycles, including a time to love and a time to hate, a time to plant and a time to uproot, a time to keep and a time to throw away. My youngest son and I had an interesting discussion about these natural cycles of life, and he offered the clever metaphor of riding a bicycle to describe how we can work with them. He said, *“There is a time to pedal and a time to coast.”* *(Repeat)* I hope that you will allot time to pedal—to practice your Karis Fellowships tools, to make a living, and to contribute to someone else’s life. I also hope that you will allot time to coast—to rest, to enjoy the fruit of what you have worked for, and to have fun. This, too, is part of your glory. Both pedaling and coasting reveal our willingness to submit to natural limitations and live in the cycles designed for us, declaring our glory as God’s creatures.

Sometimes our pride system and past trauma will not allow us to coast or to pedal. This week, schedule time to use the **Tapas Acupressure Technique**, or **T-A-T**, and make an effort to unload a weight that makes coasting or cycling difficult for you.⁵ You might ask yourself: *In what area of my life is it time to coast? In what area of my life is it time to pedal? What am I resisting?*

Every ten years or so, our bodies try to recycle old unprocessed distress. We call this distress anniversary trauma. The recycling of past trauma is a natural process designed for our healing, but it can add pain and fear to our present distress.⁶ Past traumas interfere with our ability to function, and they can intensify the discomfort or pain of our present experience. That’s why it is to your benefit that you explore and process these painful experiences when they occur. You can use the **T-A-T** to unload trauma and remove its sting.⁷ So, start by asking yourself: *What was happening in my life one, ten, or twenty years ago?* *(Pause)* *(Repeat)* Do you feel any discomfort or sense of stored trauma when you think about that period in your life?

(Pause) If nothing in particular comes to mind, take this moment to ask God for help and jot down something that is distressing you right now. *(Pause)*

The T-A-T

Take the pose and breathe. If it works for you, feel free to also place the palm of one hand on your occiput. Let's begin.

- 1. Think about the problem that is distressing you today. Could it be related to something that happened in the past—perhaps one, ten, or even twenty years ago? Feel what it's like to live with this problem. Breathe deeply. *(Hold the pose for 2 minutes)***

Pause and jot down the problem. On a scale of one to ten, assess and write down how distressing this problem is for you today.

Now resume the pose and breathe deeply.

- 2. Think about what your life would be like without this problem. *(Hold the pose for 2 minutes)***

Pause and take notes.

Breathe deeply and take the pose again.

- 3. Listen to the clearing statement: *"God, thank You for healing all the origins of this problem."* *(Repeat)* Breathe. *(Hold the pose for 2 minutes)***

Pause and jot down any thoughts you might have.

Take the pose again and breathe deeply.

- 4. Listen to the clearing statement: *"God, thank You for healing all the areas of my life, mind, and body that have been misoriented by this problem."* *(Repeat)* Breathe. *(Hold the pose for 2 minutes)***

Pause and jot down any thoughts you might have.

Take the pose again and breathe deeply.

- 5. Listen to the clearing statement: *"God, thank You for healing all the places in me that get something out of holding on to this problem."* *(Repeat)* *(Hold the pose for 2 minutes)***

Pause and take notes.

Again, take the pose and breathe deeply.

- 6. Listen to the clearing statement: *"I forgive everyone and everything that I have blamed for this problem, including God and myself."* *(Repeat)* *(Hold the pose for 2 minutes)***

Pause. You might jot down what came to mind, if anything, or continue to hold the pose. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Resume the pose and breathe deeply.

- 7. Listen to the clearing statement: *“I ask forgiveness from everyone and everything that I have harmed by holding on to this problem, including my True Self and God’s purposes.” (Repeat) (Hold the pose for 2 minutes)***

Pause and write down any thoughts that you might have.

Write down how you now feel about the problem and, on a scale of one to ten, rate and make a note of the intensity of your feelings. Compare this number with your assessment in step 1. Jot down anything you may have learned from this training.

It is astonishing how much old stress our bodies carry. By processing that old stress, we offer our bodies support and become the cause of our own healing. What marvelous creatures we are!

Our prayer might go something like this:

*God of Creation, I want to live in cycles as Your creature. Teach me when to pedal and when to coast.
(Repeat)*

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about the Toolbox?”)

0:30 SHARING

1:00 BIBLE TEACHING

The wisdom of the Book of Proverbs helps us put into practice KF Confession 7:

We commit now to live in reality, choosing to believe rather than judge.

Last week I taught you that there are two levels of karis cause and effect. When we choose to live at the first level of karis, we actively lay the foundation of orientation. We simply give to God and the Creation the gift of obedience and become a cause in our own lives. At this level, we prepare good soil for the seed that we and God will plant into our lives. The result is predictable; we reap the Fruit of the Spirit and a more peaceful and stable life.

The second level of karis is more mysterious and requires more trust because the results cannot be predicted. For me, this level is the most exciting, and I love being with people who are training hard to live here. At this second level of karis level, we plant seeds by doing good to others and by serving our community. We refuse to manipulate or predict an outcome or an effect that we imagine will benefit us. We plant the seeds, but we do not know how those seeds grow, nor do we try to guess. We simply rest, wait, and then watch what happens. With a courageous and open heart, we trust God and the Creation to marvelously respond to the offering of our gifts and service.

The three steps of this second level of karis are:

1. **Love your neighbor as yourself:** We learn to treat very well those who support us. In Luke 10, Jesus explains that the Samaritan is the neighbor. You can read about that in KF52.
2. **Do good to the trustworthy community:** We provide support for the members of the community who are investing in their True Self. These people are members of the “household of trust”⁸—those who are trusting God and the community and are themselves trustworthy. God can trust them to fulfill their mission.
3. **Act with kindness toward the world:** We do good to those who have not yet begun the journey toward orientation.

Sowing seed into the lives of others is similar to sowing seeds into our own life. When we sow the seed of good things and good gifts, we see good outcomes from our good work although we may not know exactly how that happens.

In the Book of Proverbs, God teaches us how to decide where to sow our karis gifts. Go through the Proverbs yourself and learn how to determine which people are good soil and which are not. Those that are not good soil are often called fools or scoffers, and those that are good soil are called wise or prudent. For our own protection and benefit, God encourages us to sow into the lives of the wise and to avoid sowing into the lives of fools. Here are a few ways to spot the fools and the wise.

A Fool is anyone who is more committed to their Pride System than they are to reality.

1. Fools refuse to be corrected or taught

Proverbs 1:7 *“The fear of the Lord is the beginning of knowledge; fools despise wisdom and instruction.”* The first characteristic of fools is their resistance to correction or instruction. So, if you see people resisting instruction or wisdom, you know that they are poor soil for the investment of your resources. They may actually like instruction if it matches their already preconceived ideas, but they will despise anything that might jeopardize their pride system. They might offer responsive words, but without any real follow-through. They may regularly show up to a Bible class, but you won’t see them taking anything to heart or changing their behavior. When confronted with their misorientation, they attack or withdraw in an effort to maintain their pride system.

Throughout the Bible we are encouraged to test the quality of the people around us to find out what kind of soil they are. What do they do with real feedback? Do they respond with interest, or do they run for cover? If they are less interested in personal growth than in playing, apologizing, or excusing and defending themselves, they are probably fools. In contrast, wise people seek counsel and instruction and are grateful for it. They represent the good soil into which the Bible encourages us to sow our seed.

2. Fools are addicted to foolish behavior

Proverbs 13:19 *“Desire realized is sweet to the soul, but it is an abomination to fools to depart from misorientation.”* Another characteristic of foolish people is their misoriented behavior. The desires of the wise produce sweetness in the soul, but fools have compulsive cravings that result in choices that sour and harm their souls. The compulsion behind these foolish choices is as forceful as religious

fanaticism. Being unable to satisfy their cravings is not just abhorrent to them, it actually assaults their self-worship system.

3. Fools are quick-tempered

Proverbs 12:16 *“A fool’s vexation is known at once, but a prudent man covers dishonor.”* Fools have not developed *makrothumos*, or long-temperedness. They speak before they think, and they act rather than endure. When their pride is threatened, you can see at once that they are not interested in honoring you or God. They are untrustworthy; they will not take responsibility for their own emotions, and they cannot cover for others.

4. The business of fools is deceit and illusion

Proverbs 14:8 *“The wisdom of the prudent is to understand his own way, but the folly of fools is deception.”* Fools are only interested in the illusions they create. They disregard real evidence; they deceive and are deceived. Foolish people are not interested in the truth about their own lives or the lives of others, and they refuse to admit that they are the cause of their own problems. Wise people seek to understand why they do what they do. They make the effort to learn to do something different.

5. Fools will cause you harm

Proverbs 13:20 *“Whoever walks with wise people becomes wise, but the companion of fools will suffer.”* This is one of my life verses. I have always looked for wise people to spend time with, but, before KF, the compulsive needs of my Idol Self often drove me to become the companion of fools, and around them I suffered much more than was necessary for my growth. I found out the hard way that this proverb is a direct cause and effect statement that predicts what will happen if we put time and resources into certain kinds of people. I became my own cause. I was miserable *be-cause* I would not recognize a fool when I saw one.

The Book of Proverbs helps us commit to reality. We choose to believe rather than judge what we see in ourselves and others. The wisdom of the Proverbs teaches us how to look for good soil for the careful sowing of our seed. When you want to know what kind of people you are dealing with, speak your reality moderately, be honest, or offer a gift and see what happens. Are they foolish or wise? In what areas? You don’t have to judge foolish people as evil or bad. If you judge them, you won’t be able to follow the instruction of the Proverbs. Simply believe that they want to live the way they do and then decide whether you want to be a part of that. Those who demonstrate the qualities of wise people are good investments. When you discover someone who has chosen the path to wisdom, pour your gifts into them and reap the rewards of karis.

Jesus had no illusions about people; He understood that their choices revealed their quality. In Matthew 7:20, Jesus says, “So then, you will know them by their fruits.” He is teaching us the principle of *words and works*. What a person says is not real evidence. What a person does—their works—shows you what kind of person they are and whether or not you can trust them. Even though we may long to believe whatever institutions or people tell us, we need consider their track record of decisions and outcomes before we trust their guidance and act on it. Believe the works, not the words. We can apply this principle to ourselves. We want to believe that we are a certain kind of person, but the fruit of our lives is the only real evidence of our quality. So, if you want to be wise, don’t discount the evidence of the fruit in your own life and in the lives of those around you.

As your True Self develops, you will naturally disentangle yourself from illusions and recognize the quality of the people around you. You may begin to distance yourself from the people who can harm you through their foolish choices. You won't have to cut these people off completely, but you will learn how to protect yourself from foreseeable harm while you pursue your true glory.

Take a few weeks to read the Book of Proverbs and make a note of the characteristics of the wise person and the fool. Note any instruction about the kind of people you would be wise to spend time with and those you would do well to avoid. Consider the quality of the lives of those around you and decide how much of your resources you want to invest.

Our prayer might go something like this:

*God of wisdom, show me how to be wise, and show me who is wise so that we might walk together.
(Repeat)*

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about the Bible teaching?")

1:10 INTEGRATION

Sip some purified water and assume a meditation posture. You might prepare to take some notes. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

Here is our integration focus: *Consider allowing God to show you the quality of someone's life. That someone may be yourself. (Repeat) (Pause for 15 seconds)*

In KF, we are committed to living in reality, learning to believe rather than judge. We are not looking for faults and imperfections; we are seeking to know and to believe the truth, to recognize what is wise and what is foolish, both in ourselves and in others. Our commitment to reality naturally leads us to the Believe It Path, which is paved with the wise guidance of the Proverbs.

Assume a meditation posture, and breathe. *(Pause for 15 seconds)*

The FAITH Process

(Choose from each section a few sentences that are meaningful to you)

Feelings

What are you feeling right now as you *consider allowing God to show you the quality of your own or another person's life*? Honor your feelings as you observe this person. How would you describe them? Breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Awareness without judgment

Allow your experience to rest in your awareness as you *consider allowing God to show you the quality of your own or another person's life*. Notice any struggle you might have with this experience. Perhaps you want to judge or explain what you see. Notice the struggle. *(Pause)* Feelings and passing thoughts are not right or wrong; they just are. You might use a long exhaling breath like a sigh and just allow this reality to be what it is. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Inquiry: What is my body saying?

Observe what your body is doing as you *consider allowing God to show you the quality of a person's life*. Notice your body's sensations. *(Pause)* For example, you might say to yourself, "Oh, this is what discouragement and dismay feels like in my body" or, perhaps, "This is what relief and guidance feels like." *(Pause)* You might feel frustration because you sense no change in your body, or you might feel nothing at all. Just observe and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Talk to Jesus

You might imagine that you are leaning back in the safe and loving arms of Jesus as together you *consider the quality of someone's choices, including your own*. Do you feel compelled to judge this "reality check" as good or evil, or a mixture of both? *(Pause)* What do you believe when you consider the truth about this person? What story do you want to tell? *(Pause)* Have you told this story or experienced these same feelings in the past, perhaps ten or twenty years ago? *(Pause)* Could you be experiencing fear—perhaps the fear of reality? Observe your experience as just information, and breathe with a long exhaling breath. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Heal

For thousands of years, human beings have been feeling like you do when they have discovered the reality of their own or another's life. Consider how the life of Jesus exposed the quality of the lives around Him. You are not alone in your feelings and experience. You are a human creature and can empathize with the whole human race as it observes both the foolish and the wise. *(Pause)* Can you allow the foolish and the wise to make their own choices? *(Pause)* Breathe, and from a foundation of compassion, rest in the peace that comes from living in reality. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Pause. Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about the integration?")

1:28 ENDING PRAYER

Dear Father and Creator,

We are very grateful for the created cycles that guide us to our healing. Hold us in the power of this new understanding as You help us make friends with reality. Lead us to the next step in our healing this week as we co-labor with You to reorient our lives for a more effective flow and to flourish in our connection with our True Self, with the realities of our community, with the rest of Creation, and with You, for the honor and glory of our Lord Jesus. Amen.

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about this meeting?")

1:29 ANNOUNCEMENTS

*Begin praying for the students who are registering for the NHG book study. Pray that God will remove any obstacles in their path.

*(*Except when preparing for the Jubilee year)*

¹ Phil. 4:7.

² John 14:27.

³ James 3:18.

⁴ www.britishacademyofsoundtherapy.com/the-healing-power-of-your-voice.

⁵ en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Tapas_Acupressure_Technique.

⁶ www.psychologytoday.com/us/blog/how-be-yourself/201609/5-ways-deal-anniversary-reactions. Hendriksen, Ellen. "5 Ways to Deal with Anniversary Reactions." *How to Be Yourself: Quiet Your Inner Critic and Rise Above Social Anxiety*, accessed October 16, 2018.

⁷ en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Tapas_Acupressure_Technique.

⁸ Gal. 6:10.